not being a pale imitation of China but to use its biggest calling card to push for a federal democratic system similar to ours. But we don't seem to be reading the writing on the wall and remain pro-status quo." Not all experts subscribe to this view, though. Many believe that India is following the right policy in backing the ruling dispensation as the Myanmarese army will continue to control the levers of power in any democratic dispensation. That's because the 2008 constitution enjoins that 25 per cent of the Parliament be reserved for serving military officers. Saran believes that India should engage with those opposing the army by "doing a discreet asset liability analysis and knowing which groups we could work with and take care of our security concerns".

Pakistan's military rulers, too, suffered a shock in the recent past, after they backed the move to oust



**"INDIA SHOULD TAKE A LEAF OUT OF CHINA'S PLAYBOOK AND WORK TOWARDS MAKING ITS ENEMIES DEPENDENT ON IT. IN ECONOMICS, IT CAN GET MAXIMUM LEVERAGE"**

**–ASHLEY J. TELLIS** *Senior Fellow, Carnegie Endowment for International Peace*

Imran Khan as prime minister through a no-confidence motion in Parliament in April 2022. Khan was arrested on various charges last May, leading his protesting supporters to storm the Lahore corps commander's house and forcing army chief Gen. Asim Munir to crack down on their leaders. With Khan and his party, the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaaf (PTI), disqualified from contesting the February general election, the military establishment suffered their second shock when Khan-backed Independents won the largest number of seats. Khan then had them join the Sunni Ittehad Council (SIC), a coalition of Islamic political and religious parties, which has now emerged as the single largest party in Parliament after a Supreme Court ruling formalised the process in July. Khan now poses a threat to both the army and the ruling political dispensation headed by Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif. And it is India that is suffering the backlash

**GROUND REPORT**

*By* **SUDEEP CHAKRAVARTI** *in Dhaka*

# AS THE FIRE WAS LIT IN BANGLADESH

My home in Dhaka is in Dhanmondi. Paddy Market. Dhaka's frenetic growth has ensured that for decades there hasn't been such a market in the vicinity. Since mid-July, there hasn't been much peace either.

On July 14, PM Sheikh Hasina angered students who were protesting restrictive quotas in government jobs for families of freedom fighters from 1971—even their grandchildren. She indirectly referred to the students as "razakars", pro-Pakistan collaborators during 1971. As students of private universities joined colleagues in public universities, the government banned both in-person and online classes in an attempt to stanch protests. Cloddishly, the government didn't factor in Gen-Z's proclivity for social media. It also hadn't factored in their distress, anger, energy and resolve.

Police and cadres of the ruling Awami League and those of its youth and student wings, Jubo League and Chhatro League, had started attacking protesters in campuses in Dhaka and elsewhere. On July 18, Dhanmondi became a battle zone. Students, now unarguably the heart and soul of an angered Bangladesh, were being hunted by police and the League's vast strong-arm ecosystem—call it mastanocracy. Protesters and passersby began to be killed in distressing numbers. Young men and women. Boys. Girls. Even children in Dhaka who had stood near windows and on rooftops. The small lane outside my apartment block on Road No. 9/A witnessed pitched battles, firing of teargas shells, rubber bullets, sound grenades and live ammunition. With data services blocked, we were adrift in analog and uncertainty.

The only certainty was of more trouble. Clearly, the League's opponents, including extremist groups, had begun to shrewdly piggyback on students' protests. This ultra-violent second stage was immaculately prepped and timed, and fronted by legions of the poor, the unemployed and unemployable. Hasina's undeniably impressive infrastructure development